

IN SOLIDARITY
A candlelight vigil by Aliah University students in Kolkata on February 22

SUBIR HALDER

THE ANIS KHAN CASE

DEATH FOR DISSENT?

By Romita Datta

For the past two weeks, thousands of villagers have been keeping vigil at a two-storeyed, half-finished house in Sarada Dakshin Khan Pada in West Bengal's Howrah, 50 km from Kolkata. It is the home of student leader Anis Khan—and the very place where he died mysteriously late in the night on February 18. His family alleges the 28-year-old former student of Aliah University in Kolkata was murdered.

Anis's father Salaam claims that four men—one of them in police gear—had barged into his home looking for his son and pushed him off the second floor. They left, announcing "operation successful". The family scrambled to get help for Anis, who lay in a pool of blood, but most people in the village were away at a religious function nearby.

Politically active and, to many, 'anti-establishment', Anis was a vocal critic of some of the policies of the Mamata Banerjee government. He had also taken part in the protests against the Citizenship (Amendment) Act in 2019. His death, claimed by supporters as 'political murder', is now the subject of a special investigation team (SIT) probe ordered by the Trinamool Congress (TMC) government. The local police have registered a murder case, but the SIT probe is expected to reveal if they had mishandled the case. Salaam claims the local police station, in Amta block, sent a team to his house eight hours later, and only after he had shared pictures of Anis's body.

Sarada Dakshin Khan Pada is now brimming with police teams and senior SIT officers are paying daily visits. But this has done little to calm down the angry villagers. On February 26, hundreds of them grouped together to block a police party that had arrived at dawn to exhume Anis's body for a second postmortem, ordered by the courts. The body could be exhumed only two days later. Anis's family had contested the first postmortem saying it was conducted without their presence.

Former Bengal IGP Pankaj Dutta believes the police faltered on several counts—they responded to the distress call late and did not follow basic protocols, such as cordoning off the 'scene'. "Anis's father claims to be the principal witness and had offered to help draw sketches of the assailants, but the police took no initiative. The two suspects rounded up have apparently cleared the test identification parade," says Dutta.

Anis was an activist of prominent Furfura Sharif cleric Abbas Siddiqui's Indian Secular Front (ISF), which had contested the Bengal assembly poll last year in alliance with the Left and the Congress. Anis campaigned extensively for the ISF. Sarada Dakshin Khan Pada residents say his rising popularity may